

BENCHMARK™ INTERNATIONAL

COMMERCIAL & FACILITY SERVICES | MARKETING, SALES & TECH-ENABLED SERVICES | ENGINEERING, ARCHITECTURE & CONSULTING | FINANCIAL & INSURANCE SERVICES | STAFFING & HUMAN CAPITAL

BUSINESS SERVICES

Q4 2026 M&A Sector Report

OCTOBER 2026 - JARED HARDIN | MANAGING DIRECTOR | BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL

The quarter in brief

Business services companies enter the fourth quarter of 2026 with acquirers active in all five segments covered in this report and with financing more expensive than at any point this year. Global deal value fell 41% in the third quarter after a record first half, following a Federal Reserve rate increase in September and a 10-year Treasury yield above 5%. The measures closest to founder- and family-owned companies moved the other way: the median multiple on transactions of $5 million to $50 million reached 5.8x in the second quarter, the highest since early 2022, and 87% of transactions above $5 million drew three or more offers.

41%

Fall in global deal value in the third quarter, after a record first half

5%+

10-year Treasury yield in mid-September, following a Federal Reserve rate increase

5.8x

Median multiple on transactions of $5 million to $50 million, the highest since early 2022

87%

Share of transactions above $5 million that drew three or more offers

THE FIVE SEGMENTS AT THE START OF THE QUARTER

SEGMENT	WHERE THE MARKET STANDS	WHO IS BUYING	BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL: CLOSED IN THE TRAILING 24 MONTHS, AND LIVE
Commercial & Facility Services	APi Group grew 10.1% organically in Q2 2026 and Cintas agreed to buy UniFirst for about $5.5 billion; hardcopy device shipments fell 7.0% while the listed testing groups grew 5% to 7%	Pye-Barker with 22 acquisitions in the first half of 2026, Allied Universal with eight in three months, DEX Imaging with six, SGS with 14, and EQT with a £10.9 billion offer for Intertek	21 closed, 40 live
Marketing, Sales & Tech-Enabled Services	US advertising revenue is forecast to grow 9.6% in 2026; promotional products distributor sales rose 2.5% in Q2; Gartner expects IT services spending to grow 5.3%	Private equity-backed agency platforms, Publicis and Havas, Accenture and Cognizant in technology consulting, and regional promotional products distributors	23 closed, 53 live
Engineering, Architecture & Consulting	Engineering firms report a median backlog of 12 months while architecture billings are contracting; federal surface transportation funding steps down after the infrastructure law expired	Bernhard Capital with a $1.0 billion agreement for Bowman, private equity-backed platforms such as Ardurra, and employee-owned consolidators such as Salas O'Brien	13 closed, 24 live
Financial & Insurance Services	Commercial insurance premiums fell 2% on average in Q2 2026 and broker organic growth slowed; advisory firm transactions fell 9% in the first half while assets acquired rose 88%	Aon with a $17 billion agreement for USI, the $7.7 billion purchase of a majority of Baldwin, and private equity-backed agency and wealth aggregators	3 closed, 10 live
Staffing & Human Capital	Median staffing revenue growth of 5% is the highest since late 2022; temporary employment remains 21% below its 2022 peak	Staffing firms and sponsors acquiring skilled trades, engineering, healthcare and consulting capability	7 closed, 15 live

Higher rates have reduced the debt available for each transaction and have slowed the largest deals. The acquirers named in this report are for the most part companies that already own a platform in the sector, and their purchases of well-run private businesses depend less on new borrowing than the largest transactions do.

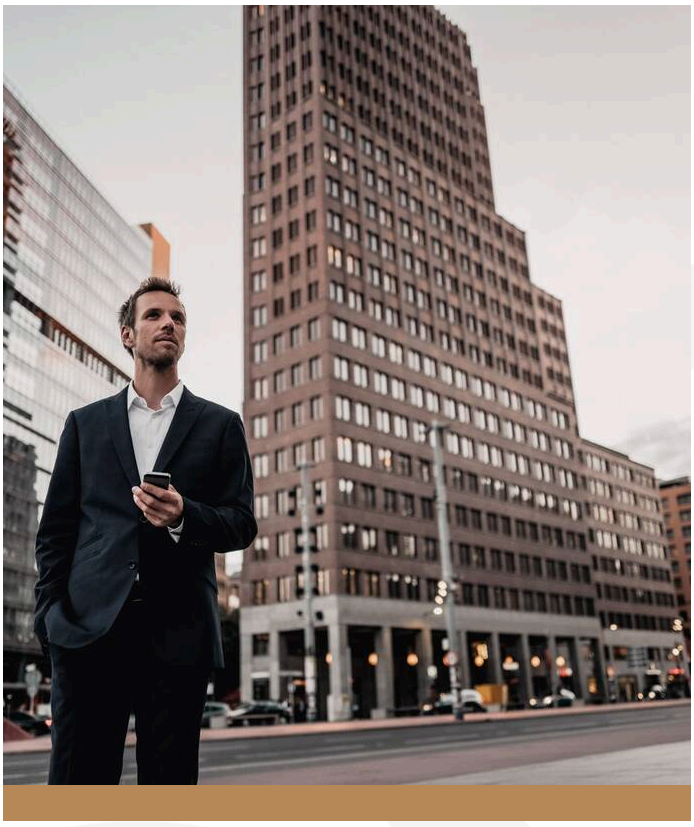
The median multiple on transactions of $5 million to $50 million reached 5.8x in the second quarter, the highest since early 2022.

Deal market: a record first half, then a rate shock in the third quarter

Global announced M&A reached $2.8 trillion in the first half of 2026, up 48% on the prior year and the highest first-half total since LSEG began keeping records in 1980, although the number of deals fell 9% to roughly 24,000, a six-year low (Reuters, LSEG data, July 1, 2026). The third quarter reversed the trend in value: global volume fell 41% from the second quarter to $993 billion, the first quarter under $1 trillion since mid-2025, and Reuters attributed the drop to rising borrowing costs (Reuters, October 1, 2026). North America recorded 10,230 transactions worth $2.37 trillion through nine months, up 33%, with third-quarter value of $560.4 billion running 23% below the same quarter of 2025 (Mergermarket, October 1, 2026).

Borrowing costs rose sharply over the same months, as the Federal Reserve raised its target range by 25 basis points to 3.75% to 4.00% on September 16, 2026, stating that inflation remains elevated (Federal Reserve, FOMC statement). Consumer prices rose 3.4% over the twelve months to August, with energy up 16.3% (BLS, CPI), and the 10-year Treasury yield moved above 5% in mid-September (Vanguard, September 17, 2026). The underlying economy is still growing: real GDP rose at a 2.2% annual rate in the second quarter (BEA), unemployment stood at 4.2% in September with payrolls up 29,000 (BLS, Employment Situation, October 2, 2026), and banks reported commercial lending standards basically unchanged in the second quarter (Federal Reserve, Senior Loan Officer Opinion Survey, July 2026).

Private equity carries a large inventory of companies it needs to sell and a large pool of capital it needs to invest, and both conditions favor a well-prepared private seller. Bain counted 32,000 unsold portfolio companies worth $3.8 trillion at the end of 2025, almost 40% of them held for more than five years, alongside $1.3 trillion of buyout dry powder (Bain & Company, Global Private Equity Report 2026). US private equity deal value fell to $177.3 billion in the second quarter of 2026, down 37.5% from the first quarter, and add-on acquisitions made up about three-quarters of the buyout transactions completed in the quarter (PitchBook, Q2 2026 US PE Breakdown). PwC estimates that clearing the existing private equity inventory at the current pace would take nine years (PwC, US Deals 2026 Midyear Outlook). A purchase by a platform the sponsor already owns is smaller and easier to finance at current rates than a new platform investment, which is why sponsor-backed companies appear as the buyer in so many of the transactions in this report.



The data for companies the size of most founder- and family-owned businesses has held up better than the headline figures.

LOWER-MIDDLE-MARKET INDICATOR	LATEST READING	PERIOD	SOURCE
Average purchase price, completed middle-market transactions	7.0x trailing adjusted EBITDA, down from 7.3x in Q1	Q2 2026	GF Data via ACG
Total debt on platform deals	2.9x EBITDA, down from 3.4x	Q2 2026	GF Data via ACG
Average senior debt pricing	7.8%, up from 7.2%	Q2 2026	GF Data via ACG
Median multiple, deals of $5 million to $50 million	5.8x, up from 5.5x and the highest since Q1 2022	Q2 2026	IBBA and M&A Source Market Pulse
Median multiple, deals of $2 million to $5 million	4.0x EBITDA	Q2 2026	IBBA and M&A Source Market Pulse
Deals above $5 million receiving three or more offers	87%; one in three received ten or more	Q2 2026	IBBA and M&A Source release
Time from engagement to close	11 to 12 months	Q2 2026	IBBA and M&A Source release
Cash received at close	83% to 92% of price	Q2 2026	IBBA and M&A Source Market Pulse
Deals that include an earnout	24%, with a median earnout equal to 34% of the closing payment	Deals closed in 2025	SRS Acquiom 2026 Deal Terms Study via Fasken
Deals in which management retains equity	21%	Deals closed in 2025	SRS Acquiom 2026 Deal Terms Study via Fasken
Who buys lower-middle-market companies	Private equity and independent sponsors 45% of closed deals, down from 61% in 2021; search funds 14%; individual investors 13%	2025	Axial
Middle-market company earnings	Revenue up 3.1%, EBITDA up 3.7% year on year	April and May 2026	Golub Capital Altman Index

The same survey reports that 60% to 90% of sellers, depending on deal size, had done less than a year of planning before going to market, and that retirement drove between 45% and 72% of sales. McKinsey expects about six million small and mid-sized US businesses to change hands by 2035, and more than half of small-business owners are now over 55 (McKinsey, The great ownership transfer).

Federal tax law is settled for sellers planning a 2026 or 2027 closing. The top long-term capital gains rate remains 20%, and the estate and gift exemption stands at $15 million per person, indexed, under the One Big Beautiful Bill Act of July 2025 (Tax Foundation). The same law raised the qualified small business stock exclusion to $15 million for stock issued after July 4, 2025, restored 100% bonus depreciation and made the 20% pass-through deduction permanent (HBK CPAs & Consultants).

COMMERCIAL & FACILITY SERVICES

Contracted, inspection-driven revenue is drawing the most active consolidators

22
Pye-Barker acquisitions in the first half of 2026

10.1%
APi Group organic revenue growth in the second quarter

$5.5B
Value of the Cintas agreement to acquire UniFirst



Commercial and facility services hold the most active acquirers in business services, because the work is contracted or mandated, it repeats on a route or an inspection schedule, and each acquired branch adds density to a network the buyer already operates. Cintas, which serves more than one million business customers over approximately 12,500 local delivery routes, agreed in March 2026 to acquire UniFirst for about $5.5 billion, and UniFirst's shareholders have approved the transaction (Cintas, fiscal 2026 annual report; American Laundry News, July 6, 2026).

Fire protection and life safety. APi Group reported second-quarter 2026 revenue of $2,254 million, up 13.3% and 10.1% organically, with an adjusted EBITDA margin of 13.8% and a backlog above $5 billion (APi Group, July 30, 2026). APi described CertaSite, a Midwest provider with about $90 million of revenue that it agreed to buy in December 2025, as an "inspection-first" business that moves it toward earning more than 60% of revenue from inspection and service (APi Group, December 10, 2025). Pye-Barker Fire & Safety completed 57 acquisitions in 2025 and a further 22 in the first half of 2026, more than 100 in two years, across fire alarm, sprinkler, suppression and security alarm companies (Security Systems News, March 18, 2026; Pye-Barker, July 30, 2026).

Security services. The SDM 100 ranking of electronic security dealers recorded recurring monthly revenue of $740 million for 2025, up 7%, with 90% of ranked dealers growing that revenue and 76% operating in commercial accounts (SDM Magazine, May 4, 2026). In guard services, Allied Universal closed eight acquisitions between May and July 2026 with about $205 million of combined annual revenue (Allied Universal, September 22, 2026), while Securitas reported flat organic sales in the second quarter (Securitas, July 24, 2026). The Bureau of Labor Statistics counts 1.3 million security guards at a median wage of $18.29 an hour, which makes the wage escalation terms in a guard company's customer contracts a central diligence item (BLS).

Painting and property maintenance. ABM Industries grew revenue 4.2% to $2.3 billion in its fiscal third quarter, with 2.1% organic growth and an equal contribution from acquisitions (ABM, September 8, 2026). FirstService Residential grew 4% on new contract wins (FirstService, July 23, 2026), and BrightView's maintenance revenue rose 1.8% while its adjusted EBITDA fell 15.1% (BrightView, August 4, 2026). Regional platforms are doing much of the buying: 4M Building Solutions has made 16 janitorial acquisitions since January 2023 (Business Wire, July 21, 2026), and Landscape Workshop acquired three commercial landscape maintenance businesses in August 2026 to reach more than 50 locations in 16 states (Utah Business, August 27, 2026). Labor is the common constraint, with 2.4 million janitors and building cleaners earning a median $17.71 an hour (BLS).

Managed print and document services. Equipment demand is contracting while the independent dealer channel continues to grow revenue. IDC reported worldwide hardcopy peripheral shipments of 17.2 million units in the second quarter of 2026, down 7.0% year on year (IDC, September 8, 2026). The Cannata Report's 40th Annual Dealer Survey, drawn from 415 dealerships, found that 67% of dealers grew revenue, by 14% on average (The Cannata Report, October 30, 2025), that 47% of dealers now offer managed IT services, and that 73% of those dealers grew the line, by an average of 28.8% (The Cannata Report, managed IT findings). Dan Doyle Jr., chief executive of DEX Imaging, told the publication that dealers need to commit fully to IT, with print representatives supplying the leads and technical specialists closing the sale (The Cannata Report, September 18, 2026).

The buyer pool is concentrated in a small number of acquirers that are moving quickly. DEX Imaging, owned by Staples, completed its sixth acquisition of 2026 in September, UBEO Business Services has announced four, and Pacific Office Automation has closed three, including its entry into Houston, and 45% of surveyed dealers said they planned to acquire a dealership or service company (The Cannata Report, acquisition trends). The manufacturers are consolidating as well: Xerox bought Lexmark for $1.5 billion in 2025 (Pulse 2.0, July 30, 2026), and Ricoh, Toshiba Tec and OKI now manufacture their multifunction devices through one joint venture, ETRIA (Ricoh, February 13, 2025). A dealer's value therefore rests more on its customer contracts, service organization and IT revenue than on the brand it carries, and the terms of its dealer agreements on a change of ownership deserve an early reading. In records and information management, Iron Mountain reported second-quarter 2026 revenue of $2.0 billion, up 18.5% (IT Brief, August 7, 2026).

Testing, inspection and certification. The largest listed companies are growing and acquiring at the same time. SGS reported first-half 2026 sales of CHF 3,683 million, up 7.6%, with organic growth of 5.6% and 14 bolt-on acquisitions completed in 2026 by the date of the release, and it closed its purchase of Applied Technical Services, a North American testing, inspection, calibration and forensics provider, on January 12, 2026 (SGS, July 23, 2026). Bureau Veritas reported first-half organic growth of 5.0% and raised its 2026 guidance to mid- to high-single-digit organic growth (Quartr, Bureau Veritas first-half 2026 results), and UL Solutions grew second-quarter revenue 6.6% organically with an adjusted EBITDA margin of 26.8% (UL Solutions, August 4, 2026).

Private equity is committing capital to testing at every size. In June 2026 the board of Intertek, the UK-listed testing group, unanimously recommended an offer from a company controlled by EQT of £60 in cash per share plus a final dividend of 107.7 pence, which values Intertek at an enterprise value of £10.9 billion and represents a 62% premium to the closing price on April 9, 2026 (Business News Today, June 18, 2026). KPMG records the transaction at $14.6 billion and places it among the largest global private equity deals of the second quarter (KPMG, Pulse of Private Equity Q2 2026). In the United States, TIC Solutions, which was formed in August 2025 when Acuren completed its acquisition of NV5 Global, announced on August 18, 2026 that it had completed three further acquisitions with about $90 million of combined annualized revenue (TIC Solutions, August 18, 2026), and Transcat paid $84 million in cash for Essco Calibration Laboratory in August 2025 (Transcat, August 5, 2025).

Buyers in testing and inspection pay for accreditation, mandated recurring revenue and certified staff. Accreditation and licensure take years to obtain and limit the number of firms that can perform a given test or inspection. Revenue recurs because the work is required by a regulator, an insurer or a customer's quality system, which makes it less sensitive to the economy than project work. Certified technicians and inspectors are scarce, so an acquisition is often the fastest way for a larger group to add capacity in a new region.

COMMERCIAL AND FACILITY SERVICES TRANSACTIONS

BUYER	TARGET	WHAT THE TARGET DOES	SOURCE AND DATE
Cintas	UniFirst	Uniform rental and facility services; about $5.5 billion	Cintas, March 10, 2026
EQT	Intertek	Testing and certification group; £10.9 billion enterprise value	Business News Today, June 18, 2026
Pye-Barker Fire & Safety	Union AlarmTronic	Family-owned alarm, access control and video company, New Jersey	Pye-Barker, September 29, 2026
Pye-Barker Fire & Safety	Suppression Systems, Inc.	Fire suppression, Pacific Northwest	Pye-Barker, August 31, 2026
Sciens Building Solutions	Southern Fire Control	Fire protection	PrivSource, January 20, 2026
APi Group	CertaSite	Fire and life safety inspection, Midwest; about $90 million of revenue	APi Group, December 10, 2025
Allied Universal	Aegis Protective Services and Admiral Security Services	Guard services and security technology; both closed in June 2026	Allied Universal, September 22, 2026
4M Building Solutions (O2 Investment Partners)	Bluegrass Commercial Cleaning and Rainbow Maintenance Services	Janitorial services, Kentucky and Illinois	Business Wire, July 21, 2026
Landscape Workshop	Aero Groundtek, Gold Landscape and Lawn Butler	Commercial landscape maintenance in Dallas, Salt Lake City and Orlando	Utah Business, August 27, 2026
DEX Imaging	Image 2000	Office technology dealer, California and Las Vegas, eight branches	The Cannata Report, September 17, 2026
Pacific Office Automation	On Demand	Office technology dealer, Houston, Texas	The Recycler, August 31, 2026
UBEO Business Services	CEI and ABR Digital Office Solutions	Office technology dealers, Raleigh-Durham, Georgia and South Carolina	UBEO, April 14, 2026
TIC Solutions	WDI, GeoVerra and Core Group	Utility data, surveying and commissioning; about $90 million of revenue	TIC Solutions, August 18, 2026
SGS	Applied Technical Services	Testing, inspection, calibration and forensics; closed January 12, 2026	SGS, July 23, 2026
Transcat	Essco Calibration Laboratory	Calibration services; $84 million in cash	Transcat, August 5, 2025

Purchase prices were disclosed for three of these transactions. In the office technology announcements, sellers describe the decision in terms of their employees and customers, and the acquirers describe retention of the local team as part of what they are buying.

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL IN COMMERCIAL AND FACILITY SERVICES

Benchmark International has closed 21 transactions in commercial and facility services over the trailing 24 months and has 40 engagements in progress as of October 1, 2026. Cintas bought a regional book of recurring fire system inspection and maintenance work in FPS Technologies, AI Fire added sprinkler and special systems contractors in Arkansas and Montana, and Phenna Group and Scientific Safety Alliance each added testing and certification capacity.

SELLER (LINKED)	BUYER AS ANNOUNCED	WHAT THE SELLER DOES
Gilco Restoration	Thomasville Restoration	Fire and water damage restoration, Williamsburg, Virginia
Matheson Painting	An undisclosed buyer	Commercial and industrial painting, Pasco, Washington
High Tech Solutions - Systems Group	AI Fire	Special systems design, installation and service, Montana and Wyoming
Fast Response Onsite Testing	Relentless Health	Mobile workplace drug and health testing
Pacific Green Protection	Cresswell Ventures	Armed and unarmed security services, operating as Echelon Protective Services
Alumitec	The January 23rd Company	Restoration, cleaning and maintenance of architectural metal facades
Briggs Engineering & Testing	Phenna Group	Inspection, testing and quality control engineering
Fire Systems Technology	AI Fire	Full-service fire sprinkler contractor, Arkansas
Bison Gardens	An undisclosed buyer	Commercial landscaping and lawn maintenance
Metals Testing Services	An undisclosed buyer	Non-destructive testing
Luna Laundry	All Washed Laundry	Commercial laundry serving hotels, Santa Fe, New Mexico
FPS Technologies	Cintas	Fire protection and safety systems design, installation and service, Oklahoma City
Power Maintenance Services	Platt Park Capital Partners	Painting and reconstruction for HOA and multifamily communities, Southern California
Critical Environments Professionals	Scientific Safety Alliance	Cleanroom and laboratory certification testing
NDT Repair Service & Supply	28th Day Holdings	Non-destructive testing equipment, repair and calibration
Landmark Lawns & Landscaping	Heartland	Commercial landscape maintenance, Burtonsville, Maryland



MARKETING, SALES & TECH-ENABLED SERVICES

Strong ad spend, a recovery in technology consulting, specialists in demand

9.6%
Forecast growth in US advertising revenue in 2026

$27.7B
North American promotional products sales in 2025, a record

5.3%
Forecast growth in worldwide IT services spending in 2026



Advertising demand is running well ahead of the wider economy in 2026. WPP Media's midyear forecast has global advertising revenue growing 8.9% this year to $1.3 trillion excluding US political spending, with the United States up 11.9% (LBB Online, June 15, 2026). MediaPost's composite of the major forecasters puts US growth at 9.6% in 2026 including political advertising and 4.4% in 2027, when the midterm and World Cup lift falls away (MediaPost, September 9, 2026). US internet advertising revenue reached $294.6 billion in 2025, up 13.9%, with commerce media up 18% to $63.4 billion (IAB and PwC, April 16, 2026). Client budgets are steadier than the media totals suggest: Gartner's 2026 survey of 401 chief marketing officers found marketing budgets at 7.8% of company revenue, against 7.7% a year earlier, with 15.3% of those budgets directed to AI (Marketing Dive, May 11, 2026).

The six largest agency groups are diverging sharply, and their restructuring is creating both buyers and sellers of mid-sized agencies.

GROUP	LATEST ORGANIC GROWTH	PERIOD	STRATEGIC POSITION	SOURCE
Omnicom	+6.1% (core operations)	Q2 2026	Closed its acquisition of Interpublic in November 2025; $567.5 million of quarterly revenue sits in dispositions and assets held for sale	Omnicom
Stagwell	+5% net revenue	Q2 2026	Digital Transformation segment grew 18% organically	Stagwell
Publicis Groupe	+4.8%	Q2 2026	Agreed to buy LiveRamp for $2.167 billion net of cash; acquired 160over90 and Adge.AI	Publicis Groupe
Havas	+2.5%	Q2 2026	North America up 6.4%; acquired Archrival in the United States	Havas
Dentsu	+0.3%	H1 2026	Americas down 5%; sale of the international business stalled in January; 3,400 roles being cut	AdNews
WPP	-4.7% (revenue less pass-through costs)	H1 2026	Reorganized into four operating units under a new chief executive; more than £200 million of disposals expected	WPP interim results

Omnicom's integration of Interpublic removed more than 4,000 positions and folded FCB, DDB and MullenLowe into other networks (Strategy, December 1, 2025). The holding companies are directing their own capital toward data and technology assets, and the announced mid-market transactions of the past twelve months cluster in four areas: agencies specialized in one vertical such as healthcare, legal or home services; firms with proprietary audience data or retail media technology; experiential and event businesses; and promotional products and print distributors joining larger platforms.

Outsourced sales and brokerage. Advantage Solutions, the largest listed sales and marketing agency for consumer packaged goods brands, grew second-quarter 2026 revenue 1.8% to $889.5 million while its adjusted EBITDA fell 12.2%. Revenue in its Branded Services segment fell 20.1%, which management attributed to constrained client spending, insourcing and client losses, and its Experiential segment grew 19.7% (Advantage Solutions, August 5, 2026). Buyers of independent brokers and manufacturers' representatives therefore look closely at the length of each principal relationship and at how much revenue rests on any one brand.

Promotional products. ASI measured North American distributor sales at a record $27.7 billion in 2025, up 4.2%, with nearly 90% of distributors raising prices, by about 11% on average, to offset import costs, and with distributors above $5 million of revenue growing 9.3% (ASI, January 21, 2026). Growth slowed to 1.8% in the first quarter of 2026 and 2.5% in the second, with firms under $1 million of revenue flat and larger firms growing about 4% (ASI Central, July 14, 2026). 4imprint's first-half revenue rose 1% while its operating profit fell 16% on tariff-related supplier costs (4imprint, August 5, 2026), and PPAI's economist described 2025 as a year in which many distributors sold more and made less (PPAI).

Digital strategy and consulting. Gartner forecasts worldwide IT services spending of $1.57 trillion in 2026, up 5.3% after 3.8% growth in 2025 (Gartner, July 27, 2026). Accenture reported fiscal 2026 revenue of $74.2 billion, up 6%, and spent $4.9 billion on acquisitions during the year (Accenture, October 1, 2026), and Cognizant grew second-quarter revenue 4.5% and completed its $634 million acquisition of Astreya (Cognizant, July 29, 2026).

Education technology consulting. The E-Rate program that funds school and library connectivity has a cap of $5.2 billion for the funding year that began on July 1, 2026, against estimated demand of $3.5 billion, and the FCC directed that all eligible requests be funded (FCC, May 11, 2026). The Supreme Court upheld the Universal Service Fund's contribution mechanism in June 2025 (SCOTUSblog), and the FCC ended E-Rate support for hotspot lending and school bus Wi-Fi that September (American Library Association). CoSN's 2026 survey of district technology leaders ranks cybersecurity as the top priority for the eighth year, with 65% reporting inadequate cybersecurity staffing (CoSN via K-12 Dive, May 14, 2026).

Display and signage. Signs of the Times found that 48% of sign companies grew sales in 2025, down from 70% in 2023, that 72% expect growth in 2026, and that recruiting and retaining staff is the leading threat they name (Signs of the Times, March 17, 2026). Daktronics reported sales up 7.1% and a backlog of $311.3 million in its quarter ended August 1, 2026, with commercial orders up 5.3% and live events orders down 48.8% (Daktronics, September 2, 2026), and the exhibition industry's index is forecast to grow 2.1% in 2026 (IAEE, May 4, 2026).

Artificial intelligence is changing what a marketing firm is paid for. The groups under the most pressure are reducing headcount while growth concentrates in technology-led work, and WPP Media sizes generative search advertising at $5.1 billion globally in 2026 (exchange4media, June 16, 2026). Agencies whose revenue depends on producing content or search rankings by the hour should expect buyers to examine how much of that work clients can now do themselves, and agencies with retained client relationships, first-party data and measurable outcomes should expect that examination to work in their favor.

MARKETING, SALES AND TECH-ENABLED SERVICES TRANSACTIONS

BUYER	TARGET	WHAT THE TARGET DOES	ANNOUNCED	SOURCE
Zebra Marketing	East Beach Specialties	Promotional products distributor, Mississippi Gulf Coast	October 2, 2026	ASI
Armanino	Sability	Workforce management consulting, Atlanta	September 29, 2026	Consulting.us
Wavestone	Sand Cherry	Enterprise transformation consultancy, Denver	September 15, 2026	Consulting.us
Cognizant	Astreya	IT services; $634 million	Completed by July 2026	Cognizant
An individual buyer	ID Signsystems	Architectural signage design and fabrication	May 13, 2026	Pulse 2.0
Publicis Groupe	LiveRamp	Data collaboration platform; $2.167 billion net of cash	May 19, 2026	IT Brief
OneMagnify (Crestview)	Optimal	Performance media with audience data	February 26, 2026	PrivSource
Impact XM (Riverside)	Jack Morton Worldwide	Experiential agency	February 19, 2026	PrivSource
Podean (Mountaingate)	Ad Advance	Retail media agency and technology	February 19, 2026	PrivSource
Supreme Group (Trinity Hunt)	Broth	Life sciences creative agency	February 10, 2026	PrivSource
OuterBox (WILsquare)	GRO Marketing	Performance marketing for multifamily and senior living	January 22, 2026	PrivSource
IdentiBrands (Proforma)	Absolute Ink Promotional Products	Promotional products distributor, Phoenix	January 22, 2026	PrivSource
Power Digital	Cardinal Digital Marketing	Healthcare digital agency	January 21, 2026	PrivSource
Herringbone Digital	BluShark Digital	Legal marketing and local search	January 21, 2026	PrivSource
Platinum Equity	Czarnowski Collective	Experiential and event production	January 20, 2026	PrivSource
QuinStreet	HomeBuddy	Home services performance marketing; $190 million	January 5, 2026	PrivSource
Wpromote (ZMC)	Giant Spoon	Creative and experiential agency	December 8, 2025	PrivSource
HALO Branded Solutions	What's Happening Promotions	Promotional products distributor, Gainesville, Florida	October 22, 2025	ASI

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL IN MARKETING, SALES AND TECH-ENABLED SERVICES

Benchmark International has closed 23 transactions in marketing, sales and tech-enabled services over the trailing 24 months and has 53 engagements in progress as of October 1, 2026. Acquirers in these transactions wanted a stronger position in one channel, as Market Performance Group did in consumer packaged goods sales, or greater reach in their own trade, as Vision Sign and Fusion Sign and Design did in signage and TentCraft did in displays.

SELLER (LINKED)	BUYER AS ANNOUNCED	WHAT THE SELLER DOES
MartianCraft	Walnut Capital Partners	Software design and development agency
EZlocal.com	An individual buyer	Digital presence management for multi-location businesses
Telmark Sales Solutions	Market Performance Group, a Sentinel Capital Partners portfolio company	Sales and marketing brokerage for consumer packaged goods companies
Boostr	Balius Partners	Display assemblies for school and university sports programs
Total Sales & Marketing	Retail Rex Capital	Promotional products and marketing services
522 Productions	An individual buyer	Video production agency, Alexandria, Virginia
SnailWorks	Beacon Software	Mail-tracking software for direct mailers
Capital City Printing	Infinite Legacy Partners	Commercial and merchandise printing with fulfillment, Texas
Ad Art	Vision Sign	National custom sign company
White Collar Media	MCG Group	Performance-based lead generation agency
Image Studios	NorthCoast Media Group	Commercial photography, video and CGI studio
The Brooks Group	Private investors	Account management and customer research consulting for healthcare clients
World Class Displays	TentCraft	Trade show displays and brand environments
Arrow Sign Company	Fusion Sign and Design	Custom signage



ENGINEERING, ARCHITECTURE & CONSULTING

Backlogs run a year deep, and private capital is paying for licensed talent

12
Months of work in the median engineering firm's backlog

88%
Share of engineering firms reporting open positions

$1.0B
Enterprise value of Bernhard Capital's offer for Bowman



Engineering firms enter the fourth quarter with full order books and a cautious outlook. The ACEC Research Institute's third-quarter 2026 survey recorded a median backlog of 12 months, with nearly half of firms holding a year or more of work and the strongest sector sentiment in data centers and in water and wastewater, while the same firms put the odds of a recession within six months at 41% (ACEC, August 27, 2026). ENR's 2026 ranking put the combined revenue of the 500 largest design firms at $158.7 billion, up 7.4% (ENR, April 27, 2026). Architecture is weaker: the AIA/Deltek Architecture Billings Index stood at 47.2 in August 2026, below the level of 50 that separates growth from contraction (AIA, September 23, 2026).

Federal surface transportation funding is the principal uncertainty for civil and transportation firms. The Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act expired on September 30, 2026, and the continuing resolution that runs through December 11 extends the core highway and transit programs without the law's advance appropriations of about $36.8 billion a year (Holland & Knight, August 12, 2026). NACo estimates that the extension reduces overall funding by more than 15% and eliminates the Bridge Formula Program (NACo, September 2, 2026). Firms whose backlog depends on federally funded bridge, rail and safety grants should expect buyers to ask how much of that work is already obligated.

The listed firms show where demand is strongest. Stantec's backlog reached $9.2 billion, up 17.5%, and its water business grew 13.0% organically in the first half, although organic growth in the United States was flat in the second quarter (Stantec, August 12, 2026). Tetra Tech's backlog rose to $4.49 billion (Tetra Tech, July 29, 2026), Willdan's net revenue grew 23.5% with 18% organic growth (Willdan, August 6, 2026), and TIC Solutions reported a record backlog of $1.18 billion in consulting, engineering and geospatial work (TIC Solutions, August 6, 2026).

Surveying, geospatial and forensic engineering. Specialist practices are selling to consolidators built around a single discipline. SAM Companies acquired Hyatt Survey Services in Florida and Inland Geodetics in Texas in early 2026 (Business Wire, January 21, 2026; SAM, February 25, 2026), Bowman bought a Las Vegas land surveyor in April (Bowman, August 10, 2026), and J.S. Held added Element Forensic Engineering in Canada in August (J.S. Held, August 13, 2026). In design technology, 47% of engineering firms now have a formal AI strategy, up 18 points in a year, with adoption at 82% among large firms and 11% among small firms (ACEC, March 4, 2026).

Private capital is paying for licensed talent and funded backlog. Bowman Consulting Group, a founder-led firm with more than 2,500 employees whose backlog grew 50.3% to $658.7 million (Bowman, August 10, 2026), agreed in August 2026 to be acquired by Bernhard Capital Partners for $43.00 per share, which is about $1.0 billion of enterprise value and a 58% premium to the prior closing price (Bowman, August 10, 2026). Ardurra, owned by Littlejohn & Co., made five acquisitions in 2025 and reached 2,600 employees with its purchase of the 500-person Remington & Vernick Engineers (ENR, March 10, 2026), and PSMJ counted 447 announced transactions among architecture, engineering and construction firms in 2025 (PSMJ). The constraint these buyers are solving is people: 88% of engineering firms report open positions and 96% have roles that require a professional engineering license (ACEC, August 27, 2026), the average vacancy rate is 7% (ACEC, March 4, 2026), and the Bureau of Labor Statistics projects about 22,700 openings for civil engineers each year (BLS).

ENGINEERING, ARCHITECTURE AND CONSULTING TRANSACTIONS

BUYER	TARGET	WHAT THE TARGET DOES	SOURCE AND DATE
Bernhard Capital Partners	Bowman Consulting Group	Founder-led national engineering firm; about $1.0 billion enterprise value	Bowman, August 10, 2026
Ardurra (Littlejohn & Co.)	Remington & Vernick Engineers	Water, municipal and transportation engineering, New Jersey; $97.3 million of revenue	ENR, March 10, 2026
Salas O'Brien	TechSource	Federal, national laboratory and nuclear engineering consulting; more than 500 staff	Barnes & Thornburg, January 21, 2026
SAM Companies	Hyatt Survey Services	Founder-owned land surveying and mapping, Florida	Business Wire, January 21, 2026
SAM Companies	Inland Geodetics	Land surveying, Central Texas	SAM, February 25, 2026
Blew & Associates	Jorgensen + Associates	Family-owned engineering and surveying firm founded in 1985, Fayetteville, Arkansas	Talk Business & Politics, March 25, 2026
Bowman Consulting Group	Smith & Associates Land Surveying	Land surveying, Las Vegas; acquired in April 2026	Bowman, August 10, 2026
J.S. Held	Element Forensic Engineering	Founder-led forensic engineering firm, Toronto and Calgary	J.S. Held, August 13, 2026
GHK Capital Partners	CPL	Architecture, engineering and planning, Rochester, New York	PrivSource, February 26, 2026
PRIME AE Group	Klavon Design Associates	Landscape architecture, Pittsburgh	PrivSource, February 16, 2026
Pape-Dawson	Prism Engineering	Civil and land development engineering, Louisville, Kentucky	PrivSource, February 3, 2026
Control Point Associates	Rouse-Sirine Associates	Land surveying and geospatial services, Virginia	PrivSource, January 24, 2026

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL IN ENGINEERING, ARCHITECTURE AND CONSULTING

Benchmark International has closed 13 transactions in engineering, architecture and consulting over the trailing 24 months and has 24 engagements in progress as of October 1, 2026. Surveying And Mapping, Vistal and Southeastern Surveying and Mapping each bought a regional civil engineering or surveying practice, RTM Engineering Consultants added building systems engineering in Kentucky, and architecture firms in El Paso, Dallas and Sacramento completed sales in the same period.

SELLER (LINKED)	BUYER AS ANNOUNCED	WHAT THE SELLER DOES
MNK Architects	The Stonewall Group	Architecture firm, El Paso, Texas
Guide Architecture	GroveCourt Capital Partners	Healthcare-focused architecture firm, Dallas
SJB Group	Surveying And Mapping (SAM)	Civil engineering firm, Baton Rouge, Louisiana
William H. Smith and Associates	Vistal	Engineering and land surveying, Rock Springs, Wyoming
LPAS	Bluwatr	Architecture and interior design, Sacramento and Oakland, California
Engineered Building Systems	RTM Engineering Consultants	Mechanical, electrical and plumbing engineering, Northern Kentucky
SCR & Associates	Southeastern Surveying and Mapping	Engineering and surveying, northwest Florida



The median engineering firm holds 12 months of backlog, and 88% of firms report open positions.

FINANCIAL & INSURANCE SERVICES

Softer premiums slow organic growth while the largest brokers keep buying

$17B
Aon's agreed purchase price for USI Insurance Services

-2%
Average change in commercial premiums, second quarter 2026

89%
Share of first-half advisory firm deals by PE-backed buyers



Commercial insurance pricing turned negative in 2026, and the effect on an agency depends on the accounts and lines it writes. The Council of Insurance Agents & Brokers recorded an average premium decline of 2% in the second quarter, with large accounts down 3.7%, medium accounts down 1.9% and small accounts down 0.5%, and with commercial property down 6.3% while umbrella rose 5.3% and commercial auto rose 4.5% (Insurance Journal, August 20, 2026). Marsh's index showed property rates in the United States down 13% and casualty rates up 7% (Marsh, July 23, 2026). An agency weighted toward small commercial accounts and casualty lines is therefore seeing less pressure on commissions than one weighted toward large property accounts.

Organic growth at the listed brokers has slowed with pricing, and acquisitions account for most of the growth they report. Second-quarter organic growth was 7% in WTW's broking business, 6% at Gallagher, about 5% at Aon and 3% in Marsh's risk and insurance business (Insurance Business, July 31, 2026), and 6.7% at Ryan Specialty (Ryan Specialty, July 30, 2026). Brown & Brown's revenue rose 30.4% to $1.7 billion while its organic revenue fell 0.7% (Stock Titan, July 27, 2026), and Baldwin's revenue rose 30% with 2% organic growth after its $1.026 billion purchase of CAC Group in January (Insurance Business).

The largest transactions of 2026 have been purchases of the consolidators themselves. Aon agreed to buy USI Insurance Services from KKR for $17 billion in cash (Insurance Journal, September 21, 2026), and The Baldwin Group agreed to a majority sale to Sequence Holdings and DFO Management at $32.50 per share, in a transaction valued at $7.7 billion (Insurance Journal, October 5, 2026). S&P Global counted 652 insurance transactions in North America in 2025 with a combined value of $41.17 billion, compared with 674 transactions and $59.32 billion in 2024 (S&P Global, February 9, 2026).

Insurance brokerage and managing general agents. Premium written through managing general agents reached $108.7 billion in 2025, up 17.8% against 5% growth for the property and casualty industry, across nearly 800 firms, according to AM Best (Risk & Insurance, July 3, 2026). Surplus lines premium grew 2.8% to $47.6 billion in the first half of 2026 after growing 13.2% in the first half of 2025, with property premium down 13.7% (Business Insurance, August 4, 2026).

Claims adjusting. Revenue at independent adjusting firms rises and falls with weather claims, and 2026 has brought fewer of them. Crawford & Company's revenues before reimbursements were $321.4 million in the second quarter, down 0.5%, and its United States property and casualty revenue fell 10.2% on fewer weather-related claims, while its adjusted EBITDA rose 20% (Crawford, August 3, 2026). Buyers of adjusting firms therefore place the most value on daily claims and third-party administration revenue, which continues in years without a major storm.

Appraisal management. Appraisal volume depends on mortgage originations, which the Mortgage Bankers Association forecasts at $2.147 trillion for 2026, with the mix shifting toward purchase loans as higher rates reduce refinancing (National Mortgage News, August 21, 2026). Freddie Mac's average 30-year fixed rate was 7.28% on October 1, 2026, compared with 6.34% a year earlier (Freddie Mac). Class Valuation acquired Allstate Appraisal in August (HousingWire, August 18, 2026).

Wealth and financial planning. Fidelity counted 120 transactions among registered investment advisers in the first half of 2026, 9% fewer than a year earlier, while the client assets involved rose 88% to $342.9 billion, and private equity-backed buyers accounted for 107 of the 120 (WealthManagement.com, August 26, 2026). Succession explains much of the supply, because Cerulli reports that 35.3% of advisers expect to retire within ten years and that 27% are unsure of their succession plan (PLANADVISER, August 7, 2026). Dakota recorded 23 wealth management transactions in August 2026 (Dakota).

Trading technology. Broadridge agreed in February 2026 to acquire CQG, a provider of futures and options trading technology, in a transaction that extends its derivatives business (FOW, February 6, 2026).

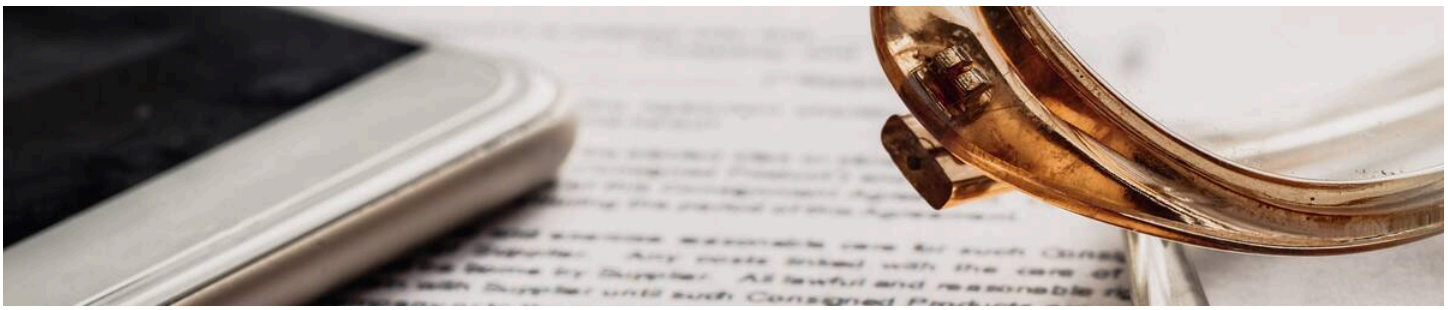
FINANCIAL AND INSURANCE SERVICES TRANSACTIONS

BUYER	TARGET	WHAT THE TARGET DOES	SOURCE AND DATE
Aon	USI Insurance Services	Insurance brokerage owned by KKR; $17 billion in cash	Insurance Journal, September 21, 2026
Sequence Holdings and DFO Management	The Baldwin Group	Listed insurance brokerage; majority sale valued at $7.7 billion	Insurance Journal, October 5, 2026
Risk Placement Services (Gallagher)	W.N. Tuscano Agency	Managing general agent and wholesale broker, Greensburg, Pennsylvania	Insurance Journal, August 17, 2026
Mile Auto	Insurance House	Managing general agent with about $100 million of premium, Atlanta	Insurance Journal, August 17, 2026
Inszone Insurance Services	Harris Insurance Services	Three-generation agency founded in 1925, West Tulsa, Oklahoma	Insurance Business, August 18, 2026
King Risk Partners	Norton and Siegel	Agency founded in 1892, Babylon, New York	Insurance Journal, October 5, 2026
EPIC Insurance Brokers & Consultants	Korotkin Insurance Group	Fifth-generation agency, Grand Rapids, Michigan	Insurance Journal, October 5, 2026
World Insurance Associates	TE Freuler	Agency founded in 1963, Somerset, New Jersey	Insurance Journal, October 5, 2026
Class Valuation	Allstate Appraisal	Real estate appraisal services	HousingWire, August 18, 2026
Hightower	Stearns Financial Group	Financial planning firm with $2.5 billion of client assets, Greensboro, North Carolina	Dakota, August 4, 2026
Mercer Advisors	NorthAvenue Financial Advocates	Advisory firm with $220 million of client assets, Columbus, Ohio	Dakota, August 25, 2026
Broadridge	CQG	Futures and options trading technology	FOW, February 6, 2026

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL IN FINANCIAL AND INSURANCE SERVICES

Benchmark International has closed three transactions in financial and insurance services over the trailing 24 months and has 10 engagements in progress as of October 1, 2026. New Era Life Insurance Companies bought a Dallas provider of marketing services to insurance companies, and Centri Business Consulting bought a firm that reviews underwriting and claims for insurers and reinsurers.

SELLER (LINKED)	BUYER AS ANNOUNCED	WHAT THE SELLER DOES
National Group Marketing Trust	New Era Life Insurance Companies	Marketing services for insurance companies, Dallas
Altair Associates	Centri Business Consulting	Auditing, underwriting and claims review for insurers and reinsurers



Private equity-backed buyers made 107 of the 120 advisory firm acquisitions that Fidelity counted in the first half of 2026.

STAFFING & HUMAN CAPITAL

The first growth in three years

5%
Median staffing revenue growth, the highest since late 2022

+7%
Forecast 2026 growth in industrial staffing revenue

21%
Temporary help employment below its March 2022 peak



Staffing revenue is growing again after three years of decline. Staffing Industry Analysts' August 2026 Pulse Survey recorded median year-on-year revenue growth of 5% across 128 firms, the highest reading since late 2022, led by engineering at 10% and industrial at 8% (SIA, September 29, 2026). The American Staffing Association's index for the second week of September stood 3.3% above the same week of 2025 (ASA, September 22, 2026). The recovery follows a deep decline: ASA measured 2025 staffing sales at $113.5 billion, down 8.5% (ASA, March 30, 2026), and temporary help employment of 2.49 million in September 2026 remains 21% below its March 2022 peak of 3.16 million (BLS data via FRED).

The segments are recovering at different speeds, and a buyer will value a firm according to which one it serves.

SEGMENT	2026 OUTLOOK	WHAT IS DRIVING IT	SOURCE
Industrial	Revenue forecast raised to +7% from +1%	Manufacturing overtime, logistics, and skilled trades for data center, power and factory construction	SIA, September 15, 2026
IT	$38.1 billion, +2%, the first growth after three years of decline	Hours up 5.3% in July and August; a net 35% of firms report rising bill rates	SIA, September 2, 2026
Healthcare	$39.0 billion, +1%; $40.1 billion in 2027	Travel nurse +2%, locum tenens +4%, per diem -7%; travel nurse gross margin of 19.9% in 2025 against about 25% before the pandemic	SIA, September 8, 2026
PEO	5.4 million worksite employees at more than 233,000 client businesses	7.2% compound annual growth since 2008	NAPEO, September 17, 2026

Public company results for the second quarter confirm the pattern. TrueBlue's revenue rose 12% with its on-demand PeopleReady business up 23% (TrueBlue, August 4, 2026), ManpowerGroup's US revenue grew 6.0% (ManpowerGroup, Form 8-K), Kforce posted a third consecutive quarter of growth at 4.5% (Kforce) and Korn Ferry's fee revenue rose 7% in its quarter ended July 31 (Korn Ferry, September 9, 2026). Robert Half's revenue was still 2% lower, although its chief executive reported that hiring demand continues to improve (Robert Half, July 23, 2026). The PEOs are the exception: TriNet's average worksite employees fell 11% (TriNet, July 30, 2026) and Barrett Business Services named soft client hiring as its primary headwind (BBSI, August 5, 2026).

Client spend routed through intermediaries, the effect of AI on junior hiring and unsettled federal rules will each appear in a buyer's diligence. Clients are routing more spend through intermediaries, with global managed service provider spend at $244 billion in 2025 and seven providers controlling more than 70% of it (SIA, September 29, 2026). AI adoption is shifting demand toward experienced workers: a Stanford and King's College London study found junior employment down 3% and senior roles up 6.7% at firms adopting AI (SIA, September 29, 2026). Federal rules remain unsettled on two fronts, with a proposed fee of about $103,000 on new H-1B hires following the court defeat of the 2025 proclamation (SIA, September 8, 2026) and a Department of Labor proposal of February 2026 to replace the independent contractor rule (US Department of Labor).

Acquirers have returned in step with the recovery, and the transactions show what they want: skilled trades and engineering talent tied to construction, specialist healthcare roles, and consulting capability that moves a staffing firm toward project ownership.

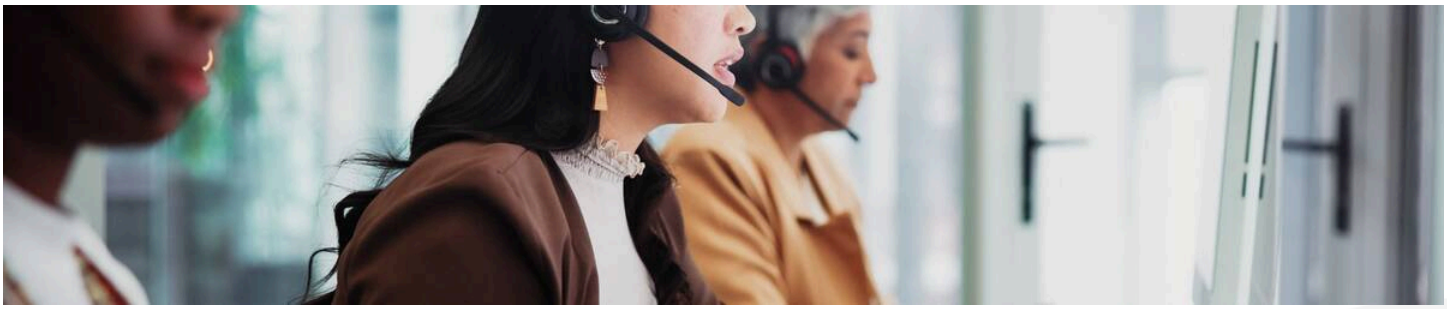
BUYER	TARGET	WHAT THE TARGET DOES	ANNOUNCED	SOURCE
VeriWorks	LaborWorx	Skilled trades and data center construction staffing	September 2026	SIA
HW Staffing Solutions	TPi Staffing	Manufacturing and technical staffing, New England	September 2026	SIA
Airswift	Three business lines of New Tech Global	Energy drilling consultants and crews	September 2026	SIA
ALKU	rocklTdata	Technology consulting, Philadelphia	September 1, 2026	SIA
CTI Staffing	PeopleServe	IT staffing, Boston, founded 1999	August 21, 2026	SIA
Aerotek (Allegis)	PAC Group	Engineering services, Troy, Michigan	August 17, 2026	SIA
Concord Holdings	Paramount Placement	Skilled trades staffing, founder-led since 2017	August 7, 2026	SIA
CHG Healthcare	KREWE Anesthesia	Nurse anesthetist staffing, New Orleans	August 2026	SIA
Korn Ferry	AMS	Recruitment process outsourcing; £850 million enterprise value	June 29, 2026	Korn Ferry
Red Dog Equity	Entegee (from Adecco)	Engineering staffing, about $180 million of revenue	June 11, 2026	SIA
Empire Workforce Solutions	Labor Now	Industrial staffing, Los Angeles	January 14, 2026	SIA
Care Career	Source Medical Staffing	Therapy and travel nurse staffing, Omaha	October 25, 2025	SIA

Korn Ferry's purchase of AMS is the one transaction with disclosed economics. The £850 million enterprise value, roughly $1.1 billion, compares with about $650 million of fee revenue and about $100 million of run-rate adjusted EBITDA, which implies approximately 11 times EBITDA for a business built on long-term outsourcing contracts.

BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL IN STAFFING AND HUMAN CAPITAL

Benchmark International has closed seven transactions in staffing and human capital over the trailing 24 months and has 15 engagements in progress as of October 1, 2026. Hi-Tek acquired an aerospace engineering and technical contract staffing firm, TiER1 Impact acquired a leadership development practice, and Health Advocates Network acquired a nurse staffing firm in northern Louisiana.

SELLER (LINKED)	BUYER AS ANNOUNCED	WHAT THE SELLER DOES
CR Seymour	TiER1 Impact	Leadership development and coaching
Mokavia Aerospace	Hi-Tek	Aerospace engineering, FAA certification consulting and technical contract staffing
MTG Services	An individual investor	Spend management and recruiting for mortgage lenders
Fitzgerald Enterprises	An undisclosed buyer	Healthcare executive and clinical placement
Medical Temps	Health Advocates Network	Nurse staffing, northern Louisiana

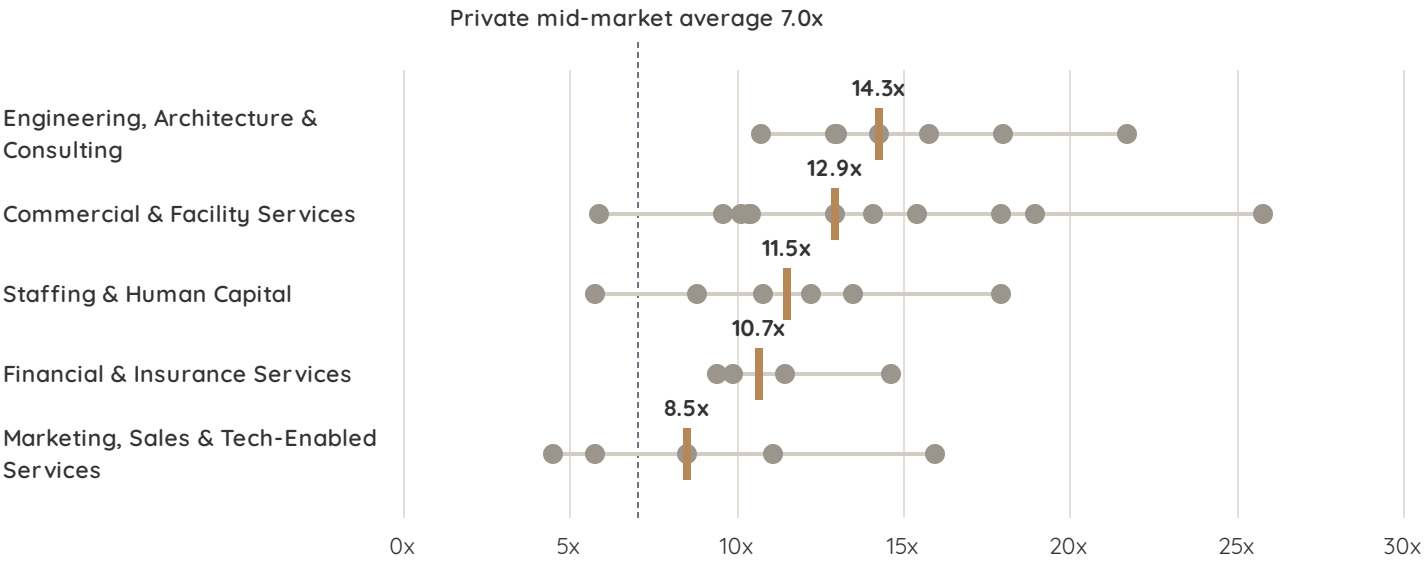


Staffing revenue grew 5% at the median in August 2026, the highest reading since late 2022.

PUBLIC-MARKET VALUATION REFERENCE

Listed engineering and commercial services companies trade above 12x EBITDA, and marketing companies trade below 9x

Enterprise value to trailing twelve-month EBITDA, listed companies by segment



Each dot is one company, the gold bar is the group median and the dashed line is the private-deal average from GF Data for Q2 2026. Robert Half, Insperity and Baldwin are excluded because their trailing multiples exceed 50x, and Marsh McLennan, Aon and Gallagher are not included. StockAnalysis statistics pages for 33 companies, retrieved October 2 and 5, 2026.

Public multiples describe very large companies and are most useful for ranking the segments against one another. Engineering firms carry the highest median at 14.3x, and within commercial and facility services the route-based companies with recurring revenue, such as Cintas at 25.8x and Rollins at 17.9x, trade well above labor-intensive businesses such as ABM at 10.1x and BrightView at 5.9x. Privately held companies in all five segments are priced below these levels, principally because of size, and the GF Data and Market Pulse figures in the deal market section are the more relevant benchmarks.

COMMERCIAL & FACILITY	
BrightView	5.9x
Eurofins Scientific	9.6x
ABM Industries	10.1x
Bureau Veritas	10.4x
Mistras Group	10.5x
Intertek	12.9x
FirstService	14.1x
SGS	15.4x
Rollins	17.9x
APi Group	19.0x
Cintas	25.8x

ENGINEERING	
AECOM	10.7x
Stantec	13.0x
TIC Solutions	13.0x
Tetra Tech	14.3x
Willdan Group	15.8x
Jacobs	18.0x
Bowman Consulting	21.7x

STAFFING	
AMN Healthcare	5.7x
Korn Ferry	8.8x
Randstad	10.8x
Barrett (BBSI)	12.3x
TriNet	13.5x
Kforce	18.0x

FINANCIAL & INSURANCE	
Brown & Brown	9.4x
Crawford & Company	9.9x
WTW	11.5x
Ryan Specialty	14.6x

MARKETING	
Dentsu Group	4.5x
Advantage Solutions	5.8x
Publicis Groupe	8.5x
Stagwell	11.1x
WPP	15.9x

Benchmark International's activity in these segments

Benchmark International has closed 67 transactions in these five segments over the trailing 24 months and is working on 142 further engagements as of October 1, 2026. Marketing, sales and tech-enabled services is the largest group on both counts, commercial and facility services is the second largest, and 69 of the 142 engagements are on the market now.

SEGMENT	CLOSED IN THE TRAILING 24 MONTHS	ENGAGEMENTS IN PROGRESS	OF WHICH ON THE MARKET
Commercial & Facility Services	21	40	17
Marketing, Sales & Tech-Enabled Services	23	53	28
Engineering, Architecture & Consulting	13	24	9
Financial & Insurance Services	3	10	3
Staffing & Human Capital	7	15	12
All five segments	**67**	**142**	**69**

The buyers in the announced transactions were predominantly operating companies. Of the 44 Benchmark International transactions named in this report, more than half were sold to a company in the seller's own or an adjacent field, including the publicly traded Cintas and platforms backed by private equity such as Al Fire, Market Performance Group and Phenna Group. The remainder went to investment firms, search funds and individual buyers, most often where the business was smaller and the owner wanted continuity for staff and customers.

The reasons these buyers gave for acquiring fall into three groups, which are expansion into a new geography, the addition of a service the buyer did not yet offer, and the addition of a business to a platform that an investor already owns. An owner can use the same three reasons to identify likely acquirers, because they point to companies that serve the same customers in a neighboring region, to companies whose clients already ask for the service the owner provides, and to investor-backed platforms that are assembling businesses in the owner's field.

More than half of the Benchmark International transactions named in this report were sold to a company in the seller's own or an adjacent field.

What buyers reward and what they discount

Across the five segments, acquirers pay the most for revenue that repeats under contract and discount revenue that depends on the owner, on one customer or on work that technology is making cheaper. The specifics differ by segment, and an owner or advisor can test a business against them well before a sale.

SEGMENT	BUYERS REWARD	BUYERS DISCOUNT
Commercial & Facility Services	Inspection, monitoring and service contracts that renew each year; route density within a region; licenses and accreditation held by the company; managed IT revenue alongside print; a tenured technician bench	Revenue concentrated in installation projects or equipment sales; licenses held personally by the owner; dependence on one end market or one manufacturer; equipment in need of reinvestment
Marketing, Sales & Tech-Enabled Services	Retained client and principal relationships; depth in one vertical such as healthcare, legal or home services; proprietary data or technology; a management team beyond the founder	Project revenue that restarts each year; one client or brand above a fifth of revenue; hourly content or search work that clients can now produce with AI tools; product margin exposed to import costs
Engineering, Architecture & Consulting	Funded backlog of a year or more; licensed staff and a second generation of principals; public-sector and utility relationships; exposure to water, power and data center work	Ownership and client relationships concentrated in principals near retirement; backlog that depends on federal grants not yet obligated; a history of project write-offs or professional liability claims
Financial & Insurance Services	Recurring commissions and fees with high retention; commercial and specialty books; producers and advisers under contract beyond the owner; clean carrier and compliance records	Books weighted toward lines where premiums are falling; revenue tied to catastrophe claims or refinancing volume; producers or advisers who control their client relationships personally
Staffing & Human Capital	Specialty placements in skilled trades, engineering, healthcare and technology; gross margin held through the downturn; direct client relationships; recruiter tenure	Commodity light industrial and clerical volume; heavy dependence on one managed service provider program; workers' compensation claims history; reliance on visa-dependent talent

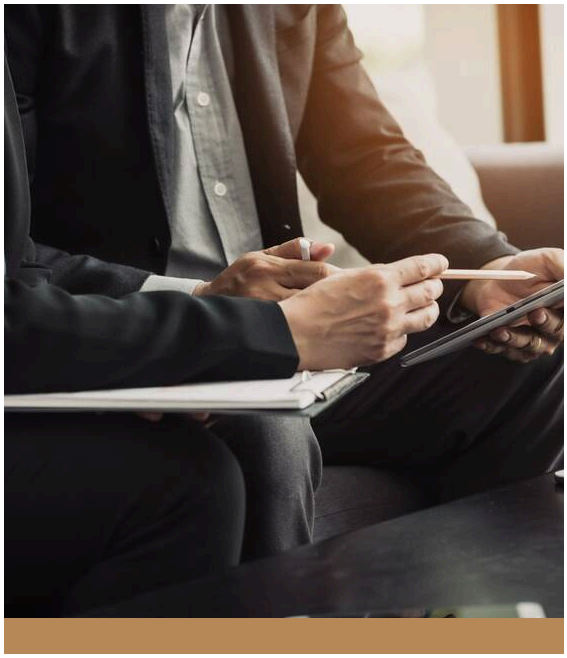
Structure carries part of the price in many of these transactions. Among the private company acquisitions that closed in 2025, 24% included an earnout and 21% left management with retained equity (SRS Acquiom 2026 Deal Terms Study via Fasken), which means that the qualities buyers reward affect the terms an owner is offered as well as the headline multiple.

Acquirers pay the most for revenue that repeats under contract, in every one of the five segments.

PREPARING FOR A SALE

Sellers who prepare early capture more of the competition for their business

In the second quarter of 2026, 87% of transactions above $5 million attracted three or more offers, and those sales took 11 to 12 months from engagement to closing, yet most sellers had spent less than a year preparing (IBBA and M&A Source Market Pulse). An owner who expects to sell within three years should therefore have reviewed financial statements, a clear record of customer contracts and renewals, and a second layer of management in place before the first buyer conversation.



Higher interest rates make this work more valuable, because lenders are advancing less debt against each dollar of EBITDA and buyers are reserving their strongest offers for businesses whose earnings they can verify quickly. The same preparation helps the accountants, attorneys and wealth advisors who counsel an owner, since tax, estate and reinvestment planning each take longer than the sale process itself.



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VALUATION

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BENCHMARK INTERNATIONAL

Transaction records as of October 1, 2026, and the transaction announcements published at benchmarkintl.com/insights, each linked from the seller's name in the Benchmark International table that closes each chapter

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